

STARTING OVER

A Guided Journal for
Healing After Divorce

The end of a marriage is not
the end of your story.

Daniel Tesfamariam

STARTING OVER

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WHERE YOU ARE IS OKAY

Whether you initiated the divorce or it happened to you, whether it's been days or years, whether you feel relief or devastation or both - where you are right now is okay.

You might feel:

- Grief for what you lost
- Relief that it's over
- Anger at them (or yourself)
- Fear of the unknown
- Guilt about the kids
- Freedom you didn't expect
- Loneliness that takes your breath away
- All of these at once

ALL of these feelings are valid. There is no 'right' way to divorce.

PROCESSING THE END

Our story (how it began):

The breaking point:

What I lost:

What I gained (even if small):

GRIEF STAGES IN DIVORCE

Divorce IS grief - even if no one died. You're mourning:

- The future you planned
- The family unit
- The person they used to be
- Your identity as a spouse
- Financial security
- Daily routines and 'home'

The stages (non-linear - you'll bounce around):

- DENIAL:** This can't be happening.
- ANGER:** How could they do this?
- BARGAINING:** If only I had...
- DEPRESSION:** I'll never be happy again.
- ACCEPTANCE:** This is my reality. I can build something new.

Where I am today: _____

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FORGIVENESS WORK

Forgiveness is NOT saying what happened was okay.

It's releasing the poison so YOU can heal.

Forgiving THEM:

What I need to release: _____

Why holding this hurts ME: _____

I choose to release: _____

Forgiving MYSELF:

What I blame myself for: _____

The truth is: _____

I deserve grace because: _____

COPARENTING COMMUNICATION SCRIPTS

Schedule changes:

'I need to adjust pickup on [date]. Can we do [alternative]?'

Concerns about child:

'I noticed [behavior]. Can we discuss how to handle it together?'

Boundaries:

'I'm not comfortable discussing our relationship. Let's focus on the kids.'

Disagreements:

'I see it differently. Can we find a middle ground for [child]?''

When they push buttons:

'I'm going to take some time before responding to this.'

GOLDEN RULES: Business-like. Brief. Child-focused. Written when calm.

REBUILDING IDENTITY: WHO AM I NOW?

Things I like that had nothing to do with my ex:

Things I stopped doing during the marriage:

Things I want to try now that I'm free:

Values that are MINE (not ours):

Who I want to become in this next chapter:

FINANCIAL RESET WORKSHEET

My new monthly income: \$ _____

Essential expenses:

Housing: \$ _____

Utilities: \$ _____

Food: \$ _____

Transportation: \$ _____

Insurance: \$ _____

Childcare: \$ _____

Debt payments: \$ _____

Total essentials: \$ _____ What's left: \$ _____

First financial priority: _____

Help I need: _____

NEW BOUNDARIES WITH MY EX

Communication boundaries:

(e.g., text only, no calls after 9pm, only about kids)

Physical boundaries:

Emotional boundaries:

What I will NO LONGER tolerate:

SOCIAL LIFE REBUILD & DATING READINESS

Friends I want to reconnect with:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

New activities/groups to try:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

DATING READINESS CHECK (be honest):

- ☐ I'm dating to connect, not to avoid loneliness
- ☐ I know what I want and won't want
- ☐ I've processed the divorce (mostly)
- ☐ I'm not trying to make my ex jealous
- ☐ I can be alone and be okay

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HEALING PROMPT 7

A boundary I'm proud of setting:

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HEALING PROMPT 8

What scares me about being single?

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A letter to my future self (1 year from now):

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Something I did today just for ME:

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HEALING PROMPT 14

Three things that went RIGHT this week:

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MY NEW CHAPTER VISION

In this new chapter of my life, I want:

My home: _____

My career: _____

My health: _____

My relationships: _____

My daily life: _____

My growth: _____

I am not starting over. I am starting FROM EXPERIENCE.

I am wiser. I am stronger. I will build something beautiful.